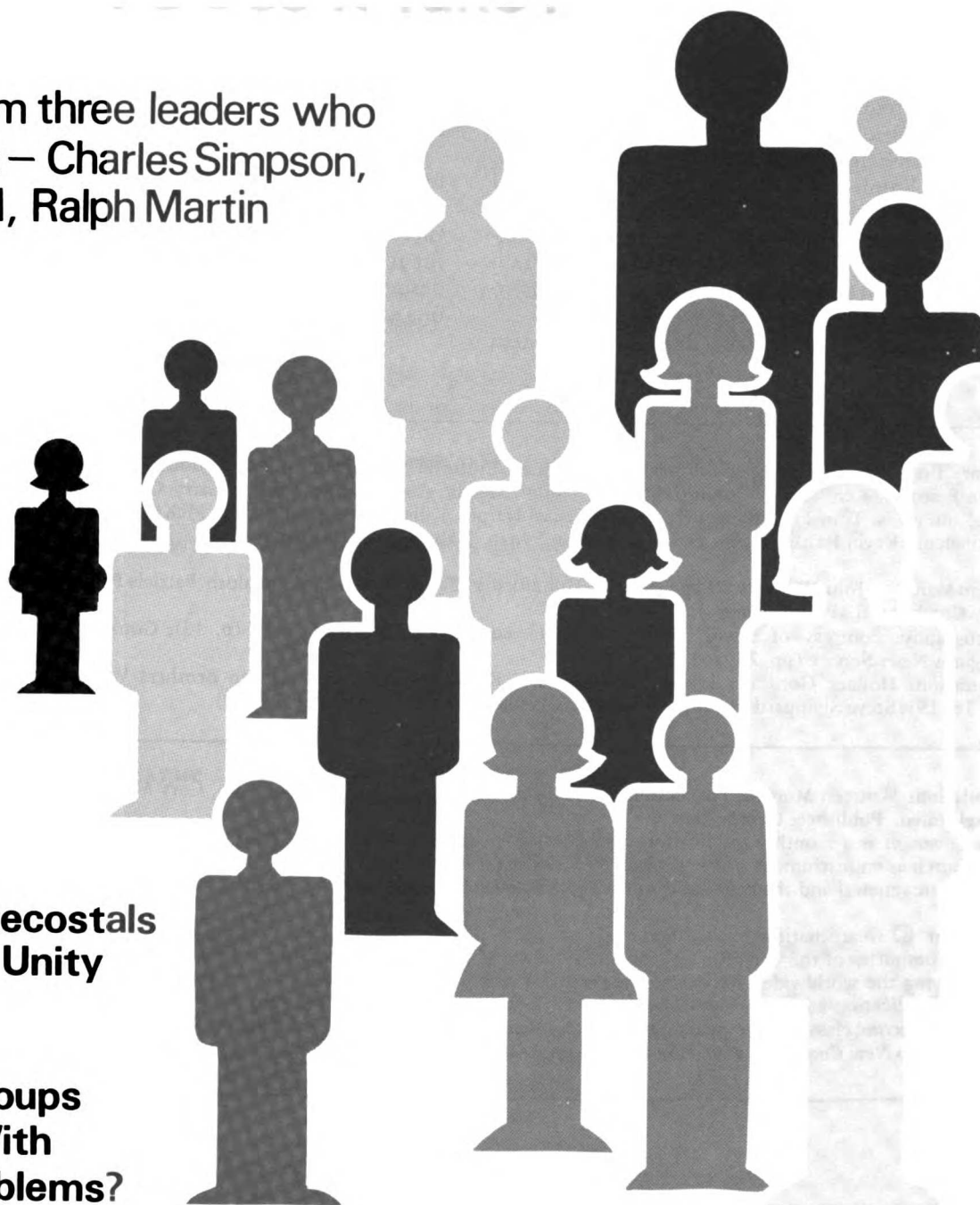


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The fragmentation syndrome, and how to overcome it.

by Veronica O'Brien

The charismatic renewal is a grace of renewal which has made its presence felt in the Catholic Church for



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over ten years now. Today, the renewal is no longer confined to the United States, but covers the five continents and encompasses all aspects of the Christian life. It has been made the subject of countless books, articles, pamphlets, and interviews. Now publishers are on the lookout for "renewal" of every kind, and magazines are intent on photographing prayer groups—all at the risk of caricaturing the living reality, which lends itself poorly to publicity.

Little by little, church authorities have declared themselves on the subject of the charismatic renewal—

hesitantly at first, after the manner of Gamaliel, then more and more warmly and confidently. A noted theologian has called the charismatic renewal "the most important movement of religious awakening known to history." Others have said that the renewal was forcing them to reexamine their theology or their exegesis, and they admit to reading Scripture with new eyes, the eyes of the heart.

On Pentecost Monday, 1975, when Paul VI welcomed a pilgrimage of some 10,000 participants in the charismatic renewal, he spoke of the renewal as "a chance for the church." At a weekly audience, he publicly recommended Cardinal Leo Joseph Suenens' book, *A New Pentecost?* Before him, John XXIII had called on all Christians to pray that a new Pentecost might come to revitalize the church. Vatican II arrived with its special grace.

And here, now, is the charismatic renewal, which is helping it take form in an unprecedented and extraordinary manner. Countless testimonies are coming in from everywhere, bearing witness to what the Spirit can effect in those who open themselves up to him. There are numerous stories about the unexpected and lasting "conversions" of both clergy and lay people who are rediscovering the meaning of their lives and of their vocations. In almost identical terms, but without knowing one another, these Christians all declare that the Holy Spirit has become experience and life for them.

In order to understand what is taking place before our eyes, we must reread the Acts of the Apostles and the description of that stupendous action of the Spirit which marked the beginning of the church. "And suddenly a sound came from heaven like the rush of a mighty wind, and it filled all the house where they were sitting. . . . And at this sound the multitude came together, and they were bewildered. . . . But Peter, standing with the eleven, lifted up his voice and addressed them. . . . and there were added that day about three thousand souls" (Acts 2:2, 6, 14, 41).

In a certain sense, the charismatic renewal prolongs this first Pentecost and reflects it in our world. The Lord calls us to express for our time the very same mystery of visible and invisible grace, remembering his promise that, by the power of his Spirit, we will do greater things than he himself did. This call involves nothing less than letting the Spirit renew the church, first in us, and then on the communitarian and ecclesial level.

This is certainly what is happening in those places

where the charismatic renewal is receiving full opportunity for development. Its fruit is appearing in a variety of striking forms, and whoever has eyes to see and ears to hear must admit that the Holy Spirit is powerfully at work. Where the charismatic renewal is able to respond to its call according to its full potential for growth and dynamism, it is bringing to life wonders of grace.

ASKING SOME HARD QUESTIONS

But a panoramic overview of the achievements, possibilities, and promise of the broader charismatic renewal does not dispense us from examining and analyzing its many local expressions. If we are to succeed in our goal of renewing the church, we must be willing to scrutinize ourselves and our individual prayer groups, and then to ask some hard questions.

What happens in places where the charismatic renewal does not get a chance to develop properly? Why do some prayer groups succeed, while others fail? There are flourishing groups that resemble magnificent trees where the birds of the air come to sing; and there are groups that have fallen short of their early promise and become like stunted trees, with half-dead shoots and withered leaves. Why?

A Loss of Vitality

Before proposing a remedy, let's take a closer look at some of these ailing trees. How do prayer groups fail? Sometimes, a group begins with only a few members but grows quickly. People can *see* the wonders of the Lord there, and the gathering attracts more and more people, until finally it is considered necessary to split it up. Smaller groups are formed from it and start meeting elsewhere.

As a result, though, the original group becomes anemic. Little by little, it loses its vitality, its impetus, and its vision; the power of the charisms is missing. It's prayer meetings become monotonous and predictable. After the few prayers of praise at the beginning, there is nothing inspiring. Testimonies become less and less frequent, substantial sharings from Scripture disappear, and teaching no longer holds the place it should. Because people know one another, and still like to get together to pray, there may remain a certain warmth about the gatherings. However, this is not the group it promised to be: it lacks life and can no longer easily transmit it. And as for the smaller groups that were

broken off, they never manage to really take shape. Their initial zeal grows dim, their numbers don't increase, and they fall into a rut.

A Closed Circle

Elsewhere, the process of decline can follow another course. Leaders of a prayer group may remain very enthusiastic and alive, and then notice sorrowfully that the rest of the group is not following along. They decide to meet on their own once a week, they form a small inner circle of people who are "on the same wave length." If they begin viewing the larger weekly meeting as secondary, they cut themselves off from everyone else.

Another type of prayer group fails because it was established as closed in on itself from the beginning and has never tried to go beyond. It remains on the level of a spiritual club and presents an impoverished picture of what the charismatic renewal contains as a hope of life.

STRENGTH FOUND IN UNITY

For all these groups that are experiencing difficulties and standing on the brink of failure, the words of the prophet Haggai prove true: "You have sown much, and harvested little; you eat, but you never have enough; you drink, but you never have your fill; you clothe yourselves, but no one is warm." But his next statement merits attention too, this time for the hope offered to those who would rebuild the Lord's temple. "Reflect in your hearts," advises the prophet "on the road you have taken" (Hag. 1:6-7).

The Jews of Haggai's time heeded his words and rebuilt the temple in Jerusalem. Likewise, those prayer groups that are struggling along should reflect on the road they have chosen, and see if it is effectively furthering the Lord's work. Specifically, they should compare the road they are following with the one taken by the groups that are flourishing in various parts of the world. Their observations will undoubtedly reveal one important principle that can make for success or failure in building the Lord's temple in our day: prayer groups that unite to form one body reach their full growth; those that split up or break off tend to wither and die.

Is this surprising? Isn't it the special vocation of the charismatic renewal to reproduce, in a visible manner, the image of Pentecost in the church of today? The renewal must, therefore, be something that can be seen and heard! Could this not be the reason why it can only be itself and have its full yield in big assemblies?

Many leaders in the charismatic renewal now agree that this is the case. Consequently, they are no longer trying to multiply the number of small groups in the hope that they will someday converge in a great stream. Instead, they are concentrating their efforts on the

formation of large, central prayer groups. These include several hundred members, if possible, and serve to link and sustain a number of smaller groups that are gathered around them.

RESOURCES FOR RENEWAL, POWER TO WITNESS

This system of center and satellite groups offers many advantages. First of all, it enables the charismatic renewal to more easily display its latent possibilities for renewing the body of Christ in a particular locality. Renewal in the Holy Spirit affects all areas of the church. You cannot dissociate prayer from personal conversion, from witnessing, from apostolic activity, from transformation of the world; they form a whole. The charismatic renewal, which is at the service of the church, is called to help invigorate it according to all these dimensions. A large prayer group will have more resources on hand for furthering the renewal of these different areas.

Secondly, all the ministries and charisms necessary to this renewal and to the full vitality of a Christian community do not usually appear within small, restricted prayer groups. The gifts of teaching, spiritual guidance, and leadership (as well as those charisms not enumerated by St. Paul, and those that get expressed in a more modern way) are as precious as they are rare; they are usually found only in groups of at least a few hundred people. And besides, there are some charisms that will not emerge unless they can be expressed in a broader context, just as a concert singer can properly demonstrate her talent only in a spacious hall; within the four walls of her room, she cannot even practice!

Thirdly, large prayer groups are important to the charismatic renewal's role in revivifying the church's liturgical life. In a large group, the charismatic renewal finds, very naturally, a certain physical and symbolic expression of worship that would appear artificial or excessive in a smaller group. Those who have seen large assemblies (such as the crowd of 10,000 who prayed and sang at St. Peter's during the 1975 International Conference in Rome, or the 40,000 who attended the charismatic mass at the Eucharistic Congress in Philadelphia last year) can grasp the power of collective prayer and understand the exuberance of faith and the witness that emerges from it. Large prayer groups make it easier to give free reign to the public expression of faith that lies at the heart of man and that the Bible everywhere invites us to.

Finally, prayer groups in the charismatic renewal should be apostolic schools of life, stressing action as well as prayer. They must become practical schools of Christianity that teach people how to transmit the gospel to the world, how to approach others, how to witness,

how to draw people to follow the Lord.

On a very concrete and practical level, this encompasses everything from learning how to speak in public and how to lead a prayer group, to helping others become aware of people's needs and eliciting or encouraging the many services that will meet them. Only a large prayer group can adequately take on these tasks and this mission.

AT THE SERVICE OF THE KINGDOM

Having reflected on the various paths we've been following, let us once again listen to the prophet, Haggai. "Climb the mountain, fetch wood, and rebuild the temple: I shall then take pleasure in it, and be glorified there, says the Lord" (Hag. 1:8).

These last words could be applied to the charismatic renewal, if it is faithful to its vocation. This is, in fact, an invitation to go ahead with the work we are doing for the Lord, not satisfied with what has been done, but inspired to action by the task that remains.

If we consider the masses of people who do not know Jesus as their master and Savior and who are waiting for us to reveal him to them, then like Jesus, we will have pity on the crowd's distress. The sight of an immense world which is hungry and thirsty for God should incite us to put all our talents at the service of the kingdom, and to see that they yield a hundredfold by perfecting them.

We have received the mission to, "Go into all the world, and preach the gospel to every creature" (Mark 16:15). The workers, therefore, must be numerous: we have to discover them, encourage them, and train them. Too many are still in the market place, idle, because no one has hired them. With numerous workers and good leadership, it would be possible to "build the temple," that is, to create the large and powerful group we are calling for. In the service of God, efficiency depends on a convergence of efforts.

Let us all unite and believe in the Holy Spirit working through us—and things will happen! We will see barriers crumble and torrents of grace sweep over a parched earth. But first we must be ready to think big ("climb the mountain"), to look for resources in men ("fetch wood"), and to coordinate our efforts. To climb a mountain is to try to see the countryside in its fullness, to enter into the plan of God according to its height, its depth, its breadth. It is to venture out, leaving the beaten path in order to follow new trails, which may be steep and uncomfortable, but which lead to new horizons.

Building the temple, therefore, does not mean limiting ourselves to the creation of a single, visible center in a city or area. This is a starting point, but the aim of



the charismatic renewal goes far beyond. Already, we are seeing among its effects a religious blossoming of an unprecedented scope that recalls the monastic impetus of the fifth century or the Franciscan renewal of the thirteenth—but on a world-wide scale. A new style of community life, which does not fit into the traditional framework of religious life, is being born. Conferences, retreats, distribution centers, pilgrimages, music ministries—a number of related yet very different projects are springing up everywhere.

And what started all this? A little group of visionaries who had the courage to think big, who agreed to enter into God's plan and to give up everything to follow him. God needs men and women; he wants to act in and through us. We are "unworthy servants," but at the same time, "fellow workers for God."

FERVOR BALANCED BY ORGANIZATION

However, it isn't sufficient to open ourselves to the Spirit and to await his inspiration without a care for organization or action. Fervor is not enough. We have to love God with all our heart and all our mind, but also with all our imagination and organizing creativity. Without falling into a stifling excess of organization, we must guard against disorder and ineffectiveness. A minimum of rules, a mode of action, well-defined goals—all this is indispensable if we are to avoid futile efforts.

The field is vast, a mighty task awaits us. Listen once again to the message of the prophet Haggai. It contains a call from the Lord to be courageous: "Courage, all you people of the country!—it is the Lord who speaks. To work! I am with you. . . Do not be afraid!" (Hag. 2:4-5).

Leaders must unite to build the temple of the living God in the world of today. They must multiply the number of fellow workers and "demultiply" themselves as well. Together, they will learn how to establish both parts of the temple—the large main prayer group, and the smaller ones gathered around it—without sacrificing the one to the other.

Support and Service

The large group, the center of leadership and life, provides impetus and support. It is where the biggest weekly meeting takes place. It is where members who have agreed to fulfill a particular service get together, unite in prayer, and distribute services and tasks among themselves. From this group, people are sent out, to it they return, like the apostles reporting back to Jesus and recounting what they had done.

The smaller groups take their place around this main center and serve to link each member to it. These small groups are also the places for in-depth exchanges, for sharing of life experiences, and for reports about local apostolic services.

Open and Apostolic

But the small groups must be sure to fulfill two essential conditions. First of all, they must always open out onto the large main group and be joined to its regular meeting. There they will find teaching, discernment, inspiration, complementarity; there, too, they will be able to collaborate in building the temple—in forming the image of the authentic charismatic renewal, in showing what real Christian community should be.

Secondly, these small groups should open out onto the street. Each member should partake actively in some form of apostolic service and so meet the various needs of the locality.

The renewal, completely open to the Holy Spirit, must be equally open to humanity. If we have any doubts, let us meditate on the last judgment, when the Lord will judge us on our obedience to his command to go to the sick, the poor, the imprisoned. Small groups, therefore, need "exits" to guard against asphyxia, but even more to respond obediently to the Lord's command.

NEW WINE, NEW WINESKINS

Let us then make the necessary sacrifices involved in building the type of temple just described.

To join with a large prayer group is not simply to attend its meetings from time to time so that our own small groups will profit. Rather, it's to be ready to give it priority. It's to accept that this large group takes precedence over the entire charismatic life of the little groups that are linked to it.

For some of us, becoming attached to a large group will mean giving up a familiar territory, one that we like and where we feel at ease. It will mean offering ourselves for greater possibilities and entering into a broader apostolic action, which we may fear. It means accepting the suffering that this option entails, as well as the possible lack of understanding of those from whom we could normally expect support.

But a special call to serve God more deeply always includes a choice that involves renunciation, separation, and sacrifice. God said to Abraham, "Go from your country and your kindred and your father's house to the land that I will show you" (Gen. 12:1). And Jesus asked his apostles to follow him and to leave their boats, their nets, and those they loved.

The one we have recognized and accepted as Lord in the charismatic renewal is the master of our lives. And he loves us. So then, why be terrified that with a new grace there comes a new method? Didn't Jesus himself say: "For new wine, new wineskins"? Now he offers us the new wineskin of the large central prayer group.

Today, more than ever, we need visionaries—true ones!—capable of "seeing big" in the service of the Lord. Let's have confidence in Jesus. He is the Lord! ■